KENTUCKY

The Bluegrass State



Kentucky has always been a state that feeds its people in common. From the earliest days of settlement, when pioneers pushed through the Cumberland Gap following Daniel Boone's Wilderness Road in the 1770s, survival in the bluegrass wilderness depended on community—shared labor, shared land, and shared meals cooked over open fire in vessels large enough to feed a crowd.

Burgoo was born from exactly that spirit.

The dish traces its roots to the frontier cooking of the late 18th and early 19th centuries, when Kentucky settlements like Harrodsburg and Lexington were still raw and young. Hunters returned from the dense forests with whatever they had taken—squirrel, rabbit, venison, wild turkey—and it all went into the pot together with whatever vegetables the season allowed. Corn, dried beans, potatoes, and wild onions thickened the broth slowly over hours until the stew became something altogether different from its ingredients—rich, smoky, deeply layered, and built for hungry people who had earned their meal.

The name itself is as colorful as its history. One enduring legend credits a French-born chef named Gus Jaubert, who allegedly fed a large crowd of Confederate and Union soldiers near Lexington during the Civil War, telling them the pot contained "burgoo"—a sailors' term for a thick oat porridge he'd adapted into something far heartier. Whether the story is precisely true matters less than what it reveals: Burgoo has always been food for gatherings, for crowds, for moments when a single pot needed to stretch far enough to feed everyone present.

By the late 1800s, Burgoo had become permanently woven into Kentucky's social fabric. Political rallies across the Bluegrass Region drew thousands, and no candidate worth his vote showed up without an iron kettle of Burgoo simmering nearby. The dish became synonymous with the Kentucky Derby as well, served at the great parties and farm gatherings that surrounded Churchill Downs each May in Louisville. James T. Looney of Lexington, known widely as the "Burgoo King," became famous in the early 20th century for cooking the stew in quantities measured not in gallons but in hundreds—stirring cast iron kettles over open flame for church picnics, racehorse celebrations, and county fairs across central Kentucky.

Over time the wild game gave way to mutton and chicken, the proportions grew more consistent, and the recipe settled into something recognizable from one Kentucky kitchen to the next—though every cook will insist their version is the only correct one.

That tradition is yours to continue. When you lift the lid on a pot of Burgoo, the steam that rises carries more than two centuries of Kentucky history with it—woodsmoke and bluegrass, horse country and hard winters, the generosity of people who always made the pot big enough for one more. Make it on a cool afternoon when you have time to let it do what it does best: simmer low, thicken slowly, and fill your kitchen with the kind of smell that makes everyone wander in to ask what's cooking.

BURGOO

Born of shared fire and shared labor, burgoo is Kentucky's great communal pot—a stew that has always fed a crowd.

Yield: 12–14 servings

INGREDIENTS

MEATS

- 1½ lb. boneless pork shoulder, cut into 1½-inch chunks
- 1½ lb. beef chuck roast, cut into 1½-inch chunks
- 1 lb. lamb shoulder, cut into 1½-inch chunks
- 2 lb. bone-in chicken thighs
- 3 Tbsp vegetable or olive oil
- 2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp freshly ground black pepper

AROMATICS & VEGETABLES (THE BASE)

- 2 large yellow onions, diced
- 3 carrots, diced
- 3 celery ribs, diced
- 1 green bell pepper, diced
- 6 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 Tbsp smoked paprika
- 2 Tbsp tomato paste

STOCK & SEASONINGS

- 8 cups chicken stock (use good quality stock for the best flavor base)
- 28 oz. crushed tomatoes
- ¼ cup Worcestershire sauce
- 2 Tbsp light brown sugar
- 2 bay leaves
- 4 fresh thyme sprigs

FINISHING VEGETABLES

- 1½ lb. russet potatoes, peeled and diced
- 14 oz. frozen lima beans
- 16 oz. frozen corn
- 1½ cups okra, sliced (fresh or frozen; thickens the stew the traditional way)

FINISHING TOUCHES

- 2 Tbsp apple cider vinegar
- ¼ cup fresh parsley, chopped
- Hot sauce, to serve

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Season the Meats*: Pat the pork, beef, lamb, and chicken dry and season all over with the salt and pepper. Dry meat is the difference between browning and steaming, so don't skip the patting. Getting a good sear is fundamental to a deep-flavored burgoo.
2. *Brown in Batches*: In a large heavy pot or Dutch oven over medium-high heat, warm the oil. Working in batches so the pot is never crowded, sear the pork, beef, and lamb until deeply browned on all sides, then the chicken thighs skin-side down until golden. Move each batch to a bowl as it finishes. Be patient here—don't rush the browning. The dark fond left behind on the bottom of the pot is the soul of the burgoo, and crowding the pan will steam the meat instead of searing it.

3. *Caramelize the Vegetables*: Add the onions, carrots, celery, and bell pepper to the same pot. Cook over medium-high, scraping up the browned bits from the bottom, until the vegetables are softened and well browned, 8–10 minutes. Stir in the garlic, smoked paprika, and tomato paste and cook for another minute until fragrant, being careful not to burn the garlic.
4. *Build the Broth*: Pour in the chicken stock and crushed tomatoes, stirring to loosen everything from the bottom of the pot. Add the Worcestershire sauce, brown sugar, bay leaves, and thyme sprigs. Return the pork, beef, lamb, and chicken (with their juices) to the pot and bring to a boil. Then reduce the heat to low, cover partially, and let it simmer for about 2 hours, stirring occasionally so nothing catches. This allows the flavors to meld and the tough cuts to become fork-tender and the chicken to fall from the bone.
5. *Shred and Return*: Fish out the chicken thighs; discard the skin and bones, shred the meat, and return it to the pot. Pull out the bay leaves and thyme stems. Break the larger chunks of pork, beef, and lamb apart with a spoon—burgoo should be shreddy, not cubed.
6. *Add the Finishing Vegetables*: Stir in the potatoes, lima beans, corn, and okra. The okra will thicken the stew the traditional way as it cooks. Simmer uncovered until the potatoes are tender and the burgoo has thickened, 30–40 minutes. Keep going longer if you want it thick enough for a spoon to stand up in the pot. (To thicken further, mash a Tbsp of the skimmed fat with a Tbsp of flour and stir it in during the last 15 minutes.)
7. *Brighten and Serve*: Off the heat, stir in the apple cider vinegar and parsley. Taste and adjust the salt. Let it rest 15 minutes before serving—or better, cool and refrigerate overnight so the flavors meld. Ladle into bowls and serve with cornbread and hot sauce on the side. Burgoo is even better the next day after the flavors have had a chance to meld further.

NOTES & TIPS

★ Burgoo is often served with cornbread or buttered biscuits for soaking up the rich broth.

ILLUSTRATION PLACEHOLDER

Burgoo — finished dish illustration

Food only (finished dish, ingredients or preparation) — no people